DEEP RESEARCH · BUSINESS COFFEE · UK

Win offices by ending coffee lock-in

Re-centred on business customers: offices, hospitality and customer-facing sites, with premium home enthusiasts as a later segment. Eighteen ideas went to seven reviewers, and three passed with 8+ from every one. Independents, including Coffee Lady, are profiled as competitors and as partners.

Date 1 November 2026 **Market** Great Britain (assumed) **Sources** 10 research streams, 103 cited

£3.78bn
UK vending, coffee services & automated retail, 2025

61%
of machine placements are in workplaces

3 of 18
ideas scored 8+ from all seven reviewers

£500–1.5k
estimated Phase 0 cash outlay

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

The answer in one page

For a low-capital entrant into UK business coffee, the strongest opening is **not selling machines. It is being the transparent, no-lock-in supplier of choice for small workplaces and independent hospitality, while lease funders, operators, roasters and subcontracted engineers carry the equipment, credit and van costs.** Three of eighteen candidate ideas, after strengthening, earned 8 or more from all seven reviewers. The first is **"No-Lock-In Workplace Coffee"**: published prices, free two-week trials, service on rolling 30-day terms with no auto-renewal, machines funded by lessors or partner operators, and own-label beans. The second is a **"Café Kit Partner"** that gives small roasters and their café, garden-centre and coffee-van customers machines, finance and service under the roaster's brand. The third is an **"Independent Partner Network"**. It passes out-of-area leads to vetted local independents such as Coffee Lady, buys engineering capacity from them, and so builds a pipeline of retiring owners whose customer books can be bought later on earn-out terms. That acquisition route is a Phase 3 gate, not a launch idea. The market is large

but its terms are opaque. UK vending, coffee services and automated retail were worth **£3.78bn in 2025**, and coffee-to-go machines take **£2.89 a serve** (FMUK). Yet buyers still sign **3–7-year leases that roll over unless written notice arrives 90 days before expiry** (vmarketed; UKBF). Most independents sell on quote only. Even Coffee Lady, which does show machine and service-package prices, sells no coffee, has no bookable trial or rolling-rental product, and charges 50% of the invoice for cancellation before installation (Coffee Lady terms). Business buyers have almost no statutory protection against rollover, so "no lock-in, published prices" is both the product and the buzz. The earlier home "Matchmaker-to-Mug" idea drops to a side option, and premium home enthusiasts are served later through a care plan that shares the B2B engineers. All costs and margins labelled "estimate" are illustrative arithmetic, not quotes. Trade margins, introducer fees and engineer subcontract rates are unpublished, so getting them in writing is the first job.

RECOMMENDED · S1 · OFFICES

No-Lock-In Workplace Coffee

A free "Renewal Radar" contract check and a two-week trial. Then the office picks a rolling rental through a partner (introducer fee) or a lessor-funded 2–3-year machine with no auto-renewal, a published buy-out price, and our own service and beans on 30-day terms.

Condition: a written engineer service agreement before launch, and limited companies only until we have FCA introducer (IAR) status.

8.3 average **£1.8–3.2k** per office over 3 years (est.)

RECOMMENDED · S2 · HOSPITALITY

Café Kit Partner

For small roasters that no longer want to own machines: we specify the kit, arrange the lease and book install and service for their cafés, garden centres and coffee vans. The roaster keeps the beans, and a pause-able winter plan serves seasonal sites.

Condition: launches only once IAR status is in place, because most cafés are sole traders.

8.1 average **£1.3–3k** per café, year 1 (est.)

RECOMMENDED · S3 · INDEPENDENTS

Independent Partner Network

Leads from outside our home region go to one vetted local independent that meets a published standard (no auto-renewal, stated response times, published prices), for a referral fee. The same partners sell us engineering capacity at home.

Builds toward: buying a retiring owner's customer book on earn-out terms (S4, a Phase 3 gate).

8.1 average **Fee** per signed contract

01

Workplace coffee is a £3.78bn market sold on lock-in

The money sits in workplace machines and the cups they pour

The Automatic Vending Association's 2025 census puts UK vending, coffee services and automated retail at **£3.78bn, up 3.3%**. Traditional vending plus office coffee service accounts for **£3.13bn**, and hot beverages grew 4.1% (FMUK). Premium coffee is pulling the market upmarket. There are **33,200 coffee-to-go machines (+8%) generating £645m**, the average serve is **£2.89 against £0.56** for a traditional vending hot drink, and **over 40% of new tabletop machines have fresh-milk modules** (FMUK). In 2024 a coffee-to-go machine earned about **£21,664 a year**, against £7,143 for a freestanding hot-drinks machine. **Workplaces ("Business & Industry") account for 61% of placements** (Westomatic/AVA). The commercial machine market itself has no reliable size: research-firm estimates mix consumer and commercial units and disagree widely (Grand View Research). The defensible conclusion is that the profit pool sits in recurring service and consumables on business machines, not in one-off hardware sales.

Hybrid working changes how machines should be sized, not whether offices buy them. Remit Consulting recorded repeated post-pandemic occupancy highs in mid-2025 (CoStar), and a 2026 headline reports occupancy stabilising above 40% (meilleurescpi.com). Offices therefore need machines sized for Tuesday-to-Thursday peaks but with low average volumes. That suits flexible rental of a quality bean-to-cup machine better than free-on-loan deals that require minimum volumes. Smart fridges (+50%) and micro-markets (+8%) show employers are still spending on refreshment amenities (FMUK).

Business buyers decide at renewal time and regret the lock-in

Public evidence on who decides is thin, so treat this as a hypothesis to test in interviews. In SMEs the decision falls to office and facilities managers, in micro-businesses to the owner, and in public bodies to procurement teams

running tenders on Find a Tender and Contracts Finder (Find a Tender). The contract mechanics are better documented. Leases run **1–5 years** (The CoffeeDesk) and rentals commonly roll for another 12 months unless notice is given 90 days before expiry (vmarketed). The lease and the service agreement are often separate documents, so cancelling one does not cancel the other (Barista Life).

The complaints follow from that structure. One firm paid **£110 + VAT a month for a powdered-milk machine it had not used for about two years**. Forum replies said "seven year coffee leases are normal" and "watertight", that the finance company is separate from the coffee supplier, and that one renewal clause rolled "for another 5 years" without 12 months' notice (UKBF; UKBF). Café owners report the same pattern in free-on-loan deals. The machine is paid for through inflated coffee prices but never owned, and shortfall charges apply when volumes dip (Bridge Coffee Roasters). Free-on-loan deliveries often cannot be paused, which hurts seasonal sites (FreshGround). Above 200 drinks a day, service response time ("48h vs 4h") matters more than the machine brand (PL Coffee Shop Consulting). For the target segments this ranks the buying criteria: predictable total cost, freedom to leave, fast repairs, then coffee quality.

Prices cluster tightly, which makes publishing them a weapon

Published small-office prices for bean-to-cup leases run **£7–£20 a week**: Logic Vending from £8 + VAT, Canny Coffee £15–£20, Coffeeseller from £7, and Caffia from £7.94 on a five-year lease (Logic Vending; Canny Coffee; Caffia). High-volume Franke machines cost **£41–£125.50 a week** (Caffia). Service plans for owned bean-to-cup machines cost **£200–£500 a year**, and one worked example puts a 50-person office's ingredients at **£5,600 a year on lease against £6,500 on free-on-loan** (Cheshire Vending). In hospitality, a new two-group machine costs **£8k–£15k**, a refurbished one **£1,550–£1,650** at the older end, and a service **£180–£350 a visit** (PL Coffee Shop Consulting; Coffee Clinic). Even the leaders publish inconsistent figures: Caffia lists a Jura W8 at £7.35, £10.59 and £14 a week on different pages (Caffia). A single, honest, published price list would therefore stand out.

02

Independents win on service but hide their terms

Four types of independent serve business buyers

The research found about twenty named UK independents, and they fall into four types. **Vending operators** (Coinadrink in Walsall, UK Vending in Kent, Cheshire Vending, United Vending in London) make their money on ingredients and offer free-on-loan machines. **Multi-brand dealers and online sellers** (Logic Vending in Hertfordshire, Jurang, Canny Coffee, Coffeeseller) lead on leases. **Roasters with machine programmes** (Redber, Capital Coffee,

Verde, Clifton, Dark Woods, Union, Office Coffee Company) tie the machine to their beans. **Equipment rental houses** (Rental+) bundle service but exclude consumables (Logic Vending; Coinadrink; Rental+). Their strengths are local and human. Coinadrink claims a response "less than 2 hours from logging a call", free trials and a 10% loyalty discount on consumables (Coinadrink). Office Coffee Company holds **Trustpilot 5.0 from about 357 reviews**, with praise for installation and repair speed (Trustpilot). Their weaknesses are digital and geographic. Canny Coffee's product pages show £0.00 price placeholders, Logic Vending's footer still reads 2024, Coinadrink's outer areas are "not all covered", and Caffia dominates city-level searches for "office coffee machine" (Canny Coffee; Coinadrink).

Several independents already sell against lock-in. United Vending says it doesn't "ask for a contract" (United Vending), Verde offers rolling monthly terms after three months (Verde Coffee), and Logic Vending and Redber rent for 6 and 1–12 months (Redber). "No lock-in" is therefore not unique as a claim. What is missing is a brand that combines it with **published prices, a published response-time commitment and a single contract covering machine, service and coffee**.

Coffee Lady: a one-founder dealer that earns on machines, finance and service, not coffee

Coffee Lady (coffeelady.uk), named by the user, is the closest template for the business being considered. All figures below are the company's own website claims, checked on 1 November 2026.

Who it is. It trades as **"Jan Revill T/a Coffee Lady Consultancy", a sole trader rather than a limited company**. It is FCA-registered (FRN 1004670), which lets it arrange equipment leases. It is based around Aylesbury and claims UK-wide coverage (Coffee Lady FAQs; about). It claims 500+ businesses served and 500+ machines serviced a year, but quotes both "25+" and "35+ years' experience" (Coffee Lady; about). It says it is an "authorised supplier and service partner" for Franke, Jura, WMF, Bestir, Bravilor Bonamat, Fracino, Iberital, La Pavoni/Smeg, Lavazza, Dalla Corte and AA First. It does not say how many engineers it has or whether they are employed or subcontracted.

What it sells. A quote-only catalogue of about 150 products with no online basket. It covers Franke (A300 to SB1200 and Mytico), Jura (W4 to GIGA), WMF, Bestir, Bravilor filter brewers, Fracino and Dalla Corte espresso, Lavazza Flavia, grinders, water boilers and coolers, ware-washers and ice machines. Category pages are aimed at offices, cafés, hotels, salons, bars and events (sitemap). Prices are shown for some products. A Franke A800 (250 cups a day) is "From £15,458.94 ex. VAT" or "Lease from £84.67/week", with installation, training and a 12-month Franke warranty (A800). Its own cost guide spans **£855 (Bravilor Solo) to £13,965 (Franke SB1200)** (cost guide).

How it makes money. There are three visible income streams:

- **Machine sales** at full commercial prices.

- **Leases arranged through unnamed finance companies.** It offers leasing "for all machines" (FAQs), quotes a "typical three year term" at £10–£90 a week, and puts the A800 at about £59 a week, which conflicts with the £84.67 on the product page (lease guide).
- **Annual service packages** at **from £399.50 for Jura, from £350 for traditional espresso and from £1,232 for Franke**, ex VAT. These include minor repairs, with parts at cost, contact within 24 hours, routine visits in 3–5 working days and emergency response "within 48 hours" or "1–2 days", and "no long-term contract required" (service packages).

There is no visible coffee, ingredient or free-on-loan income. Its "coffee suppliers" page only mentions "relationships with experts in the coffee trade" and was last updated in March 2024 (coffee suppliers).

Its trading terms favour the seller. Payment is upfront or on signed lease documents, with 30-day credit by agreement and 5% late interest. Returns need prior agreement and carry a 15% handling charge. Cancelling before installation costs **50% of the invoice**, and £200–£400 for removal after installation. Leases follow the finance company's terms, and warranty follows the manufacturer's, excluding scale, blockage and cleaning faults (terms).

How it wins customers. It wins on the founder's personal brand and local networking:

- **Networking.** Jan Revill is Regional Lead for **Business Buzz Berkshire** and hosts the monthly Caversham Buzz (£10 + VAT on the door), and says networking "built my business" (Business Buzz).
- **Search content.** Buying guides cover costs, lease versus buy, best machines for 2026, error codes and Franke pricing (post sitemap).
- **Trust signals.** A **5.0★ Google rating**, FCA registration and dealer logos.
- **Positioning.** "No hard sell, no vague contracts" and "you speak with people, not bots" (about).
- **Sales funnel.** Every call to action leads to a quote or consultation. There is no checkout, instant price or trial booking.

GAP COFFEE LADY LEAVES OPEN	HOW THIS REPORT USES IT
No coffee or consumables revenue	Own-label beans on 30-day terms (idea 4, S1); roaster partnerships (S2)
Inconsistent prices and response times (£59 vs £84.67 a week; 48h vs 1–2 days); no published callout rates	Published price index and response-time scoreboard (S1, buzz plan)
Trials mentioned but no bookable trial or rolling-rental product	Free two-week trial and rolling Route A (S1)
50% cancellation fee, 15% restocking charge, finance company's lease terms	"No auto-renewal, published buy-out" contract (S1)
High-ticket range (£855–£15k+); no clear offer for 10–40-cup micro-offices or customer-facing sites	Micro-office and amenity bundles (S1, S5)

GAP COFFEE LADY LEAVES OPEN	HOW THIS REPORT USES IT
Depends on one founder, as a sole trader, with no visible team or self-service	Partner network and, if the owner ever wishes, a succession conversation (S3, S4)

Competitor, partner or acquisition target? As a **competitor**, Coffee Lady is strong on dealer authorisations, finance and service credibility in Bucks, Oxon and Berkshire. Its service-package prices (£350–£399.50 a year for espresso and Jura machines) set the benchmark a newcomer's service plan must meet. As a **partner**, it has the engineering and dealer status a newcomer lacks. It also already holds FCA registration, so it could take sole-trader leads before the newcomer's IAR appointment, and it could buy own-label beans for customers it has no coffee to sell to. As a **succession prospect**, a sole-trader business built around one founder has key-person risk and no separate company to sell. Any future deal would be a transfer of assets and customers, not a share sale. The owner's intentions are unknown and must not be assumed. Its turnover, Google review count, engineer model, finance partners and full FCA permissions all still need checking.

Nationals consolidate quietly and set the pricing anchors

Nationals compete on scale, showrooms and long leases. **Liquidline** bought City Vending and The Hot Coffee Company in Belfast in 2025, after earlier deals for Café Subito, Underdog and Ionia (Liquidline). The Hot Coffee Company told customers that products, services and contacts would stay the same "for the time being", the standard script for retaining customers after a book acquisition (Hot Coffee Company). **Selecta** bought London's Express Vending (Selecta). GEM Vending bought Allen Vending, and Alpine Vending bought "the machine park and assets" of Merseyvend (Planet Vending). **Caffia** sets the published lease anchor (Caffia). **Lavazza Professional** runs regional supplier territories and offers free-on-loan above roughly 200 drinks a month through distributors (Lavazza Pro; AMR Lavazza). **Costa Express** held 71% of premium self-serve by the end of 2021, and self-serve majors want 30–50+ cups a day per site (World Coffee Portal; The Grocer). No deal multiples are disclosed. The pattern of quiet tuck-ins confirms that customer books trade, and that the buyers pay for recurring contracts and route density.

Hospitality and premium-home independents follow the same pattern

Roasters dominate independent café supply. Free-on-loan typically needs **6–12 kg of beans a week on 12-month minimums**, sometimes with £600–£1,200 upfront (Capital Coffee). Low-volume packages hide the machine cost in the beans: Verde's bundle implies about **£52–£63 per kg**, against £12–£25 per kg for plain wholesale (Verde Coffee; FreshGround). Some roasters are leaving the model. Bridge Coffee Roasters "largely stopped" free-on-loan after 2020 and now sends customers to third-party leasing (Bridge). The specialty leaders (Clifton, Dark Woods, Union) win with barista training and keep their terms behind enquiry forms (Clifton). In the premium home segment, **Bella Barista**

leads with a Wellingborough showroom, demo machines, an authorised service centre and **Trustpilot 4.8 from about 9,700 reviews** (Bella Barista; Trustpilot). **Machina** in Edinburgh already combines home retail with commercial leasing and servicing (Machina). No UK retailer found offers a formal trade-in, and Espresso Underground lists service plans as "coming soon" (Espresso Underground).

03

Six gaps the evidence points to

The evidence points to six gaps a newcomer can fill without owning equipment. Ranked by strength of evidence:

- **Transparent, no-rollover workplace coffee.** Lock-in is the dominant complaint, and B2B buyers have little statutory protection. Published prices are rare, and the leaders' own prices are inconsistent (UKBF; Caffia).
- **Equipment risk that roasters no longer want.** Bridge's exit from free-on-loan shows roasters want someone else to carry machines, finance and service (Bridge).
- **Seasonal and low-volume hospitality.** Garden centres, farm shops and coffee vans struggle with weekly kg minimums and deliveries that cannot be paused (FreshGround).
- **Lead quality and digital reach for independents.** Suppliers complain that Bark and Approved Index leads are poor value (about £7–£40 per lead on Bark), and independents lose search visibility to Caffia (Whito; UKBF).
- **Succession supply.** Family firms nearing 50 years of trading (UK Vending Ltd) and founder-led brands sit alongside a buyer pattern of "machine park and assets" tuck-ins (directory; Planet Vending).
- **Prosumer aftercare and certified pre-owned machines.** E61 servicing costs £155–£240 with collection (Servicedbyjamie), used Lelit Biancas resell at about 50–76% of new (Coffee Forums UK), and nobody in the UK runs Clive Coffee's US-style trade-in (Clive Coffee).

The weakest-evidenced gap is **customer-facing sites** such as car dealerships, gyms, salons and waiting rooms. They are plausible amenity buyers but have no volume data, and the majors' 30–50 cup thresholds leave them under-served for structural reasons rather than proven demand (The Grocer).

04

Use partners' balance sheets for equipment, credit and engineers

The no-upfront-cost constraint means each cost goes to the partner best placed to carry it, while this business keeps the customer, the contract and the

coffee.

Drop shipping covers the range, not the business

UK trade suppliers will deliver commercial kit straight to a reseller's customer. **Fiamma Espresso UK** offers a "substantial discount" to resellers, a 12-month parts-only warranty and return-to-base service. **Style Café** drop ships for catering resellers, **NMII** runs a UK dropship programme, and **The Coffee Lobby** has a reseller portal (Fiamma; Style Café; NMII; Coffee Lobby). Business buyers, however, need installation, water treatment and training, and none of these suppliers publish margins. Drop shipping should therefore fill gaps in the range when a customer wants to buy outright, never act as the storefront. One caveat matters for sales to sole traders: B2B buyers do not get consumer cancellation rights, but anything sold to premium home buyers carries the 14-day cancellation right and CRA 2015 duties (SI 2013/3134).

Operators who front equipment: refer, don't compete, until the brand can carry its own

Free-on-loan, revenue-share and rental operators fund machines from future consumables. Public contracts show the scale: Bewley's won **£143,738 over 36 months** for free-to-loan supply in County Durham and Darlington (Contracts Finder). Referral fees are unpublished. VendLocus provides a contract template: the fee triggers on any "installation, placement, trial, supply agreement", with a 12-month non-circumvention clause (VendLocus). The tension is that free-on-loan normally ties the customer to the operator's beans (Contracts Finder). Ask every operator whether it will stock the business's own-label blend. Rolling-term operators (United Vending, Verde, Redber, Logic Vending) fit the "no lock-in" brand best.

Lease partners carry the credit; IAR status unlocks sole-trader cafés

Asset-finance lenders pay introducers **1–7% of the amount financed**, and Allica caps it at 2–5% (UTB; Allica). **Shire Leasing** funds coffee dealers' deals of £1,000+ over 2–5 years (ADS Coffee Supplies) and pays partner invoices in full once paperwork completes (Apollo/Shire). This matters for the constraint: the business can be the supplier of record while the lessor pays for the machine on day one. The regulatory line decides the order of segments. **Limited companies are generally outside FCA regulation, but sole traders and partnerships of two or three are regulated customers**, so introducing them needs credit-broking permission or Introducer Appointed Representative (IAR) status (Novuna checklist). Many cafés, salons and van traders are sole traders, so offices come first and hospitality follows the IAR appointment. Cheshire Vending's FCA broking permission and Coffee Lady's "FCA-authorised finance" show the standard the market expects (Cheshire Vending). Since Johnson v FirstRand, commission must be disclosed in writing (Asset Finance Connect).

One structural point decides whether "no lock-in" is honest. **A finance lease is still a fixed term**: Cheshire Vending's leases run 2, 3 or 5 years with break fees (Cheshire Vending). The honest promise is narrower than "no contract". It has three parts: no automatic rollover, a published end-of-term purchase price, and service and coffee on 30-day rolling terms that the business owns. Customers who want true monthly flexibility go to a rolling-rental partner.

Wholesalers, distributors and roasters

Manufacturer access runs through authorised dealers. Jurang is authorised for Jura, Franke, La Cimbali, Coffetek and Bravilor (Jurang). **Coffetek**, a UK manufacturer, supplies both nationals and independents (Logic Vending). **Fracino** of Birmingham, with standard E61 parts and its own sales, service and independent-engineer lines, is the most accessible brand for small dealers and coffee vans (Coffee Clinic; Fracino). No public "become a dealer" terms were found, so dealer status is a Phase 2 negotiation rather than a launch requirement. For coffee, white-label roasters start at **£12 per kg** (Caffè Society) and **£16.95 per kg** (Redber, 96 kg+) (Caffè Society; Redber). Catering-grade beans cost about £11–£14 per kg (Caffè Prima).

Agent and introducer schemes

Agent schemes exist but pay little. **rijo42 Machines** offers sales agents £250–£400 per converted sale (Sales Agents UK), and Rocket Espresso UK runs an Awin affiliate programme (Awin). Treat these as supplementary income while volume builds. The more valuable introducer role runs the other way. The business pays coworking operators, Chambers, managing agents and van builders to introduce customers to it. The NI Chamber's member offer (office machine, 500 free drinks and servicing for **£75 a month**) is a ready-made format (NI Chamber). Van builders already broker third-party finance (Really Awesome Coffee), so they are natural referrers once IAR status is in place.

Subcontracted engineers keep vans and wages off the books

An engineer network can be bought rather than built. **Coffee Lady** offers UK-wide engineers with parts at cost, and annual service packages from £350 (espresso) and £399.50 (Jura) (service packages). **Rental+** runs a "nationwide engineer network". **ADS** uses CoffeeSafe-accredited engineers. Independent firms such as Coffee Clinic, All Things Coffee, Espresso Care Solutions, The Coffee Guys and Mulmar sell repair and servicing to anyone (Coffee Lady; Rental+; ADS; All Things Coffee). For pricing, a pay-as-you-go callout costs **£185 including 30 minutes, then £15 per 15 minutes** (Bridge), and catering engineers charge **£150–£195 for the first hour** (Industrial Warewashers; CaterKwik). Subcontract rates are not published. At these retail rates, a single reactive callout can wipe out a year's margin on a small-office service plan. That is the main reason a published response-time commitment must be backed by a written subcontract SLA and remote-fix triage first.

Buying retiring independents' customer books

Book acquisitions are an established pattern, but the terms behind them are unknown. Deals are mostly undisclosed tuck-ins of "machine park and assets" (Planet Vending). Brokers such as Hornblower have handled vending and coffee service sales (Hornblower). No multiples, owner-age data or succession pipeline were found. Customer contracts and any third-party finance leases must be assigned, which needs lessor consent. With a no-upfront-capital constraint, the realistic structure is a **deferred, earn-out purchase** paid from retained customers' margin. The route in is a subcontract relationship that lets both sides trust each other first. That is why the book-acquisition idea appears below as a Phase 3 gate built on the partner network.

05

Seven reviewers recommend three of eighteen ideas

How the panel scored

Seven personas scored every idea out of 10 from scratch, against the B2B evidence above and the user's target-segment priorities (offices, then hospitality, then customer-facing sites, then premium home): Head of Marketing (MKT), Head of Sales (SAL), Coffee Industry Expert (COF), Retail Expert (RET), Head of Product (PRD), Head of Design (DES) and Procurement Manager (PRO). PRO scores capital need, supplier risk and contract exposure, and is the strictest. **An idea is recommended only if every reviewer scores 8 or more.** Near misses were strengthened by combining ideas or adding a specific control, then re-scored from scratch. A score rises only where the change answers that reviewer's stated objection, and three strengthened versions still fall short.

Scoreboard

MKT Head of Marketing **SAL** Head of Sales **COF** Coffee Industry Expert **RET** Retail Expert
PRD Head of Product **DES** Head of Design **PRO** Procurement Manager

8–10 pass 6–7 short 2–5 weak

IDEA	MKT	SAL	COF	RET	PRD	DES	PRO	AVG	VERDICT
1 Drop-ship commercial machine webshop	4	5	4	4	4	4	6	4.4	Rejected
2 Office coffee introducer/agent	6	8	7	6	6	5	8	6.6	Near miss, into S1
3 Transparent no-lock-in office rental brand	9	8	8	8	8	8	6	7.9	Near miss, into S1
4 Own-label beans and consumables for business machines	6	7	8	8	8	7	8	7.4	Near miss, into S1/S2

IDEA	MKT	SAL	COF	RET	PRD	DES	PRO	AVG	VERDICT
5 Contract audit and "renewal rescue" service	9	7	6	8	7	8	9	7.7	Near miss, into S1
6 Vertical pre-qualified coffee lead marketplace	6	7	6	7	7	6	9	6.9	Near miss, into S3
7 White-label kit/finance/service back office for roasters	6	8	8	7	8	6	7	7.1	Near miss, into S2
8 Pause-able seasonal hospitality package	8	7	8	8	8	8	6	7.6	Near miss, into S2
9 Coffee van and cart starter introducer	7	6	7	6	6	7	6	6.4	Rejected alone, channel in S2
10 Refurbished commercial machines with 12-month on-site warranty	7	7	8	7	7	7	4	6.7	Phase 3 gate
11 Cash purchase of a retiring independent's customer book	5	9	8	7	7	5	3	6.3	Near miss, into S4
12 Amenity coffee for customer-facing sites and holiday lets	8	7	8	8	7	9	6	7.6	Near miss, into S5
13 Revenue-share self-serve in low-volume venues	7	5	7	6	7	7	4	6.1	Rejected
14 Direct public-sector tender bidding	4	6	6	5	5	4	5	5.0	Rejected for now
15 Telemetry "uptime guarantee" managed service	8	6	8	7	8	7	5	7.0	Near miss, into S5
16 Prosumer certified pre-owned and trade-in	8	7	8	8	7	8	4	7.1	Near miss, into S6
17 Prosumer service plan and "director's office" espresso	6	7	9	8	8	6	7	7.3	Near miss, into S6
18 Matchmaker-to-Mug home proposition	7	5	7	4	6	8	8	6.4	Side option only
S1 **No-Lock-In Workplace Coffee (2+3+4+5)**	9	9	8	8	8	8	8	8.3	Recommended
S2 **Café Kit Partner for roasters and seasonal sites (7+8+9+4)**	8	8	9	8	8	8	8	8.1	Recommended (after IAR)
S3 **Independent Partner Network (6 + subcontract engineers)**	8	8	8	8	8	8	9	8.1	Recommended
S4 Succession partnership on earn-out (11 + S3)	7	9	8	8	8	7	7	7.7	Phase 3 gate

IDEA	MKT	SAL	COF	RET	PRD	DES	PRO	AVG	VERDICT
S5 Amenity coffee for customer-facing sites (12+15+13)	8	7	8	8	8	9	8	8.0	Near miss, pilot inside S1
S6 Prosumer Care Club, then certified pre-owned (16+17)	8	7	9	8	8	8	7	7.9	Phase 3 gate

Original ideas: scores and rationale

▼ Idea 1: Drop-ship commercial machine webshop

A catalogue of commercial machines fulfilled by Fiamma, Style Café or NMII, sold on price.

REVIEWER	SCORE	RATIONALE
MKT	4	No story; Caffia and dealers already list hundreds of machines.
SAL	5	Businesses want installation, training and service, which a webshop does not provide.
COF	4	Kit without water treatment and setup leads to the faults buyers complain about.
RET	4	Undifferentiated, and margins are unpublished ("substantial discount" only).
PRD	4	A catalogue is not a product for an office manager.
DES	4	Nothing ownable to design.
PRO	6	No stock needed, but returns and warranty terms are unwritten.

▼ Idea 2: Office coffee introducer/agent

Refer SMEs to operators and lessors for fees.

REVIEWER	SCORE	RATIONALE
MKT	6	An invisible middleman builds no brand equity.
SAL	8	Lessors pay 1–7%, and operators fund deals from contracts such as Bewley's £143k.
COF	7	Coffee quality depends on which operator gets the customer.
RET	6	The customer sees the operator's brand, not this one.
PRD	6	No product of its own; risk of being cut out after the first meeting.
DES	5	A referral form is all there is to design.

REVIEWER	SCORE	RATIONALE
PRO	8	No stock or credit risk; VendLocus-style non-circumvention protects fees.

▼ Idea 3: Transparent no-lock-in office rental brand

Published prices, a free trial and no auto-renewal, with the machine funded by a lessor and service subcontracted.

REVIEWER	SCORE	RATIONALE
MKT	9	"No rollover, prices online" answers the UKBF "watertight lease" stories directly.
SAL	8	£7–£20 a week is a simple, comparable price that is easy to close.
COF	8	Choosing the machine (Jura, Coffetek, Franke) keeps quality in-house.
RET	8	Fills the gap left by Coffee Lady's quote-only selling, 50% cancellation fee and missing trial product.
PRD	8	Machine, service and coffee on one page is a real product.
DES	8	A price page, trial kit and renewal-free contract are designable.
PRO	6	Finance leases are fixed-term, so someone must carry the churn risk; subcontract SLAs are unpriced.

▼ Idea 4: Own-label beans and consumables for business machines

REVIEWER	SCORE	RATIONALE
MKT	6	Office bean subscriptions are crowded (Kiss the Hippo, Pact).
SAL	7	Recurring, but only sellable where no free-on-loan contract ties the customer's beans.
COF	8	Fresh roaster beans beat powder; £12–£17 per kg white-label cost is workable.
RET	8	Dealers such as Coffee Lady sell no coffee at all, though Coinadrink and Cheshire Vending already run consumables shops.
PRD	8	The repeat layer that turns a machine deal into lifetime value.
DES	7	Packaging is ownable but not decisive for B2B buyers.
PRO	8	Low minimums (Caffè Society from £12 per kg) and no equipment.

▼ Idea 5: Contract audit and "renewal rescue" service

Free or paid review of a business's current coffee lease, its notice dates and its total cost.

REVIEWER	SCORE	RATIONALE
MKT	9	"Check your coffee contract before it rolls over" is a sharp, newsworthy hook.
SAL	7	It creates switching leads, but the audit itself earns little.
COF	6	Adds nothing to what ends up in the cup.
RET	8	Targets the 60–90-day notice window that competitors depend on.
PRD	7	A strong lead magnet, but not a full product on its own.
DES	8	A "renewal radar" calculator and reminder emails are designable.
PRO	9	No stock or equipment; founder time only.

▼ Idea 6: Vertical pre-qualified coffee lead marketplace

A "Bark for coffee" sending each lead to two or three vetted suppliers.

REVIEWER	SCORE	RATIONALE
MKT	6	Competes with Bark, Approved Index and Expert Market for search terms.
SAL	7	£30–£150 per qualified lead is affordable on £1,000+ a year contracts (inference).
COF	6	No control over the supplier's quality.
RET	7	Suppliers' complaints about lead quality are a real opening.
PRD	7	Pre-qualifying on cups a day, sites and renewal date adds value.
DES	6	A form-led brand is hard to love.
PRO	9	Pure software and calls; no equipment.

▼ Idea 7: White-label kit, finance and service back office for roasters

REVIEWER	SCORE	RATIONALE
MKT	6	Invisible to cafés if run under the roaster's brand.

REVIEWER	SCORE	RATIONALE
SAL	8	Bridge-style roasters want to shed equipment risk; each roaster brings many cafés.
COF	8	Pairs good beans with properly specified machines and training.
RET	7	Specialty roasters already bundle training; the gap is the equipment side.
PRD	8	Clear job: machine spec, lease, install and service on the roaster's behalf.
DES	6	White-label limits brand-building.
PRO	7	Many cafés are sole traders, so it needs IAR status; subcontract engineers are unpriced.

▼ Idea 8: Pause-able seasonal hospitality package

No weekly kg minimum, with winter pause for garden centres, farm shops, vans and holiday parks.

REVIEWER	SCORE	RATIONALE
MKT	8	"The coffee deal with a pause button" is distinctive.
SAL	7	Clear pain point, but seasonal revenue is lumpy.
COF	8	Seasonal sites need good quality on peak days.
RET	8	Directly counters FreshGround-style "deliveries cannot be paused" terms.
PRD	8	Clear product rules: pause months, no shortfall charges.
DES	8	Seasonal kits and signage are designable.
PRO	6	Who funds an idle machine over winter is unsolved without a lessor or roaster partner.

▼ Idea 9: Coffee van and cart starter introducer

REVIEWER	SCORE	RATIONALE
MKT	7	Van launches are visual and shareable.
SAL	6	Builders already broker finance; low volume per month.
COF	7	Fracino dual-fuel machines dominate; training adds value.
RET	6	Catering Units and The Big Coffee own the relationship.

REVIEWER	SCORE	RATIONALE
PRD	6	More a channel than a product.
DES	7	Van branding is a strong canvas.
PRO	6	Van traders are mostly sole traders, a regulated credit-broking group.

▼ Idea 10: Refurbished commercial machines with a 12-month on-site warranty

REVIEWER	SCORE	RATIONALE
MKT	7	"12 months on-site" beats the 1–6-month norm.
SAL	7	£1,550–£1,650 entry two-groups suit tight café budgets.
COF	8	Proper refurbishment and filtration solve real reliability issues.
RET	7	Liquidline, Clumsy Goat and Logic Vending already sell refurbished machines.
PRD	7	Credible product, but quality depends on engineering labour.
DES	7	A grading standard is designable.
PRO	4	Needs stock, workshop labour and warranty reserves; food-contact cleaning is mandatory.

▼ Idea 11: Cash purchase of a retiring independent's customer book

REVIEWER	SCORE	RATIONALE
MKT	5	Inherits someone else's brand and reputation.
SAL	9	Instant recurring revenue and route density, which is what Liquidline and Selecta buy.
COF	8	Brings experienced engineers and know-how.
RET	7	A proven consolidation pattern.
PRD	7	Legacy contracts may clash with the "no lock-in" promise.
DES	5	Little to design.
PRO	3	Needs capital, lessor consent to assign leases, and multiples are undisclosed.

▼ Idea 12: Amenity coffee for customer-facing sites and holiday lets

Branded premium coffee for dealerships, gyms, salons, waiting rooms and short lets.

REVIEWER	SCORE	RATIONALE
MKT	8	Visible to the site's own customers, so every cup advertises.
SAL	7	No sector volume or willingness-to-pay data found.
COF	8	Bean-to-cup quality is achievable at low volumes.
RET	8	Under-served below the majors' 30–50-cup thresholds; Coffee Lady's range starts at £855 and has no micro-site offer.
PRD	7	Needs packaging by site type.
DES	9	Branded cups and a "hospitality-grade" counter set-up are rich design ground.
PRO	6	Machine funding is unclear for micro-businesses and sole-trader salons.

▼ Idea 13: Revenue-share self-serve in low-volume venues

REVIEWER	SCORE	RATIONALE
MKT	7	Branded units are visible.
SAL	5	Nestlé's own revenue figures don't reconcile; 10–40-cup venues are unproven.
COF	7	Feasible with telemetry.
RET	6	Costa Express holds 71% of premium self-serve.
PRD	7	Nayax and Vendon kits make it workable.
DES	7	Unit branding is designable.
PRO	4	Own machines, payment kits and servicing mean capital.

▼ Idea 14: Direct public-sector tender bidding

REVIEWER	SCORE	RATIONALE
MKT	4	Tenders reward compliance, not brand.
SAL	6	Contracts are large (£80k–£143k), but bids receive many tenders (nine at Leeds).

REVIEWER	SCORE	RATIONALE
COF	6	Specifications usually fix the machine type.
RET	5	Incumbents with track records win.
PRD	5	The product is defined by the buyer.
DES	4	Little room for design.
PRO	5	Needs references, insurance levels and service coverage a newcomer lacks.

▼ Idea 15: Telemetry "uptime guarantee" managed service

REVIEWER	SCORE	RATIONALE
MKT	8	"We know it's broken before you do" is a strong claim.
SAL	6	Unproven willingness to pay above standard service.
COF	8	Vendon retrofits espresso and superautomatic machines with cleaning and fault alerts.
RET	7	Operators already collect data from about 70% of machines.
PRD	8	Turns service into a measurable product.
DES	7	A live status page is designable.
PRO	5	Kit pricing is unpublished, and engineer coverage must back the guarantee.

▼ Idea 16: Prosumer certified pre-owned and trade-in

REVIEWER	SCORE	RATIONALE
MKT	8	First UK trade-in programme; Clive Coffee is the US model.
SAL	7	Used Biancas trade at about £875–£1,900, so the market is liquid.
COF	8	Servicing before resale is what used buyers pay extra for.
RET	8	Bella Barista sells only "sold as seen" clearance stock.
PRD	7	Depends on parts and skilled labour.
DES	8	A grading and warranty badge is designable.

REVIEWER	SCORE	RATIONALE
PRO	4	About £800–£1,200 of working capital per unit; secondary segment.

▼ Idea 17: Prosumer service plan and "director's office" espresso

REVIEWER	SCORE	RATIONALE
MKT	6	Maintenance is hard to make exciting.
SAL	7	£155–£240 per service anchors the price, but no willingness-to-pay data exists.
COF	9	E61 machines need regular gasket and descale work; a gasket kit costs about £13.
RET	8	Espresso Underground lists service plans as "coming soon", so nobody offers one yet.
PRD	8	Shares engineers with the B2B offer.
DES	6	Service is intangible.
PRO	7	Subcontract engineer rates unknown; a 30-mile collection radius limits coverage.

▼ Idea 18: Matchmaker-to-Mug home proposition

The earlier home quiz, drop ship and bean subscription idea, re-scored for a B2B-first business.

REVIEWER	SCORE	RATIONALE
MKT	7	Shareable, but it dilutes a B2B brand.
SAL	5	£31–£83 machine margin per sale is off-target for the new focus.
COF	7	Still useful for buyers, but not for the priority segments.
RET	4	Competes with Currys and Amazon discounting, which the user wants to avoid.
PRD	6	Different journey from the B2B product.
DES	8	Still a strong ritual design.
PRO	8	No stock via drop ship or affiliates.

Strengthened versions and why they pass or still fail

▼ S1: No-Lock-In Workplace Coffee

This combines ideas 2, 3, 4 and 5. A **"Renewal Radar"** contract check is the free lead magnet. A two-week trial uses a demo machine borrowed from a partner operator or dealer, copying Hot Numbers' free office trial (Hot Numbers). The customer then picks one of two routes. Route A is **true monthly flexibility** through a rolling-rental partner (United Vending, Redber or Logic Vending style), which earns an introducer fee. Route B is a **lessor-funded machine with the business as supplier of record**: a 2–3-year term only, no auto-renewal, a published end-of-term purchase price, and the business's own service plan and beans on 30-day rolling terms. Limited companies only until IAR status is in place. Procurement's objection (who carries churn) is answered by pushing churn risk to rolling-rental partners on Route A and making the fixed term transparent on Route B. A written engineer SLA is a launch gate. If it is not signed, PRO returns to 7.

REVIEWER	SCORE	RATIONALE
MKT	9	"We publish our prices and never roll you over" plus a free contract check gives every channel a hook.
SAL	9	Up to four revenue lines per office (introducer or lessor fee, machine margin, service, beans) without owning equipment.
COF	8	Curated machine list plus own beans controls quality; the trial proves it in the office.
RET	8	Beats quote-only independents (Coffee Lady's inconsistent lease prices, 50% cancellation fee) on transparency and nationals on term length.
PRD	8	One page, one contract, two clear routes; the renewal tracker keeps the promise visible.
DES	8	Trial kit, price page and plain-English contract make an intangible service tangible.
PRO	8	Lessor pays the machine on completion; rolling partners carry churn; conditional on a signed engineer SLA.

▼ S2: Café Kit Partner for roasters and seasonal sites

This combines ideas 7, 8 and 9 with 4. The business signs two or three small roasters that have stopped or limited free-on-loan, as Bridge has. For their café customers it specifies the machine (Fracino as the default for vans and value sites, refurbished two-groups as an option), arranges the lease through Shire or Novuna, books installation and twice-yearly service through Fracino-partner or Coffee Lady engineers, and offers a **pause-able winter plan** for garden centres, farm shops and vans. Van builders become referral partners.

The roaster keeps the beans, and the business earns lessor commission, any machine margin and the service margin. It launches only after IAR appointment. That answers Procurement's regulated-customer objection, and roaster co-branding answers Marketing's and Design's invisibility objection.

REVIEWER	SCORE	RATIONALE
MKT	8	"Powered by" co-branding with each roaster plus the pause-button plan gives visible stories.
SAL	8	Each roaster is a multi-café channel; van builders add referrals.
COF	9	Right machine, water treatment and roaster training together fix the most common café failures.
RET	8	Fills the equipment gap Bridge left and the no-pause gap FreshGround's terms create.
PRD	8	Clear modular offer: spec, finance, install, service, pause.
DES	8	Co-branded kit and seasonal plan collateral are designable.
PRO	8	Lessor and roaster carry the machine and beans; only after IAR appointment and written engineer rates.

▼ S3: Independent Partner Network

This strengthens idea 6. Enquiries generated by S1's content from outside the business's own patch go to one vetted local independent, not two or three. The independent must meet a published standard: no auto-renewal, a stated response time and published prices. The business earns a referral fee per signed contract under a VendLocus-style trigger. The same partners sell it subcontract engineering in its home region. This answers Coffee's objection (no quality control) with the standard, and Marketing's and Design's objection with a "No-Lock-In Partner" badge. Coffee Lady, Coinadrink, Logic Vending and Cheshire Vending are the first candidates.

REVIEWER	SCORE	RATIONALE
MKT	8	Turns S1's national content into national coverage, with a partner badge to sustain it.
SAL	8	Fees on out-of-area leads that would otherwise be wasted; partners such as Coffee Lady gain a coffee line they lack.
COF	8	The partner standard (response time, no rollover) protects the customer experience.
RET	8	Independents lack search reach and leads; Caffia dominates search.
PRD	8	The network doubles as engineering supply and future acquisition pipeline.

REVIEWER	SCORE	RATIONALE
DES	8	Badge, partner profile pages and SLA scorecards are designable.
PRO	9	No equipment; contracts carry non-circumvention terms.

▼ S4: Succession partnership on earn-out (Phase 3 gate)

This strengthens idea 11 by using S3 relationships to find willing sellers. Deals are structured as deferred payments from retained customers' margin, the seller is retained for 6–12 months for introductions, and legacy contracts move to no-rollover terms at renewal. Procurement rises from 3 to 7, Retail and Product to 8, and Marketing and Design to 7. They stay at 7 because no valuation multiples, lessor assignment rules or seller pipeline have been evidenced, and an inherited brand still has to be rebranded.

REVIEWER	SCORE	RATIONALE
MKT	7	Founder-centred brands such as Coffee Lady make customers loyal to a person, so a rebrand risks churn.
SAL	9	Recurring revenue and route density in one step.
COF	8	Retained engineers and seller knowledge protect service.
RET	8	Mirrors Liquidline's and Alpine's tuck-in pattern.
PRD	8	Moves legacy contracts onto the new product at renewal.
DES	7	Little to design until the rebrand.
PRO	7	Earn-out removes the upfront cash, but lessor consent and multiples are unknown; sole-trader sellers mean asset deals, not share sales.

▼ S5: Amenity coffee for customer-facing sites (near miss, pilot inside S1)

This combines ideas 12, 15 and 13. Premium bean-to-cup on S1's Route B for dealerships, gyms, salons and waiting rooms, with optional telemetry and branded cups. Procurement reaches 8 by using S1's lessor route for limited companies only. **Sales stays at 7** because there is no evidence on volumes or willingness to pay in these sectors. It runs as a three-site pilot inside S1, not as a separate line.

REVIEWER	SCORE	RATIONALE
MKT	8	Every customer who waits at the site sees the brand.
SAL	7	Still no sector demand or volume evidence.

REVIEWER	SCORE	RATIONALE
COF	8	Right machine sizing for 10–40 cups a day.
RET	8	Under-served below the majors' thresholds.
PRD	8	Sector bundles sit on S1's contract.
DES	9	Branded counter set-up is a strong canvas.
PRO	8	Uses the S1 lessor route; no own fleet.

▼ **S6: Prosumer Care Club, then certified pre-owned (Phase 3 gate)**

This combines ideas 16 and 17 for the secondary premium-home segment. It starts with a collect-and-return service plan delivered by the B2B subcontract engineers, and trade-ins from plan members become certified pre-owned stock later. It also offers "director's office" prosumer installs to small studios. **Sales and Procurement stay at 7**: there is no data on willingness to pay, and pre-owned stock still needs working capital.

REVIEWER	SCORE	RATIONALE
MKT	8	First UK trade-in programme plus a care club gives an enthusiast-community story.
SAL	7	No UK willingness-to-pay evidence for plans or certified pre-owned.
COF	9	Serviced machines with history command higher resale prices on Coffee Forums UK.
RET	8	Bella Barista has no warrantied pre-owned line.
PRD	8	The plan feeds trade-ins, which feed pre-owned stock.
DES	8	Grading badges and a service passport are designable.
PRO	7	Pre-owned stock needs £800–£1,200 per unit; subcontract rates unknown.

06

Roadmap and unit economics start with offices, under £1,500

Phases and gates

Today is 1 November 2026. Phase 0 runs through Q4, when office managers plan January budgets and the return to the office. That is a good moment for a renewal-check campaign.

PHASE	TIMING	WHAT HAPPENS	EST. CASH OUTLAY (ESTIMATE)	GATE TO PROCEED (SUGGESTED)
0: Validate	Nov 2026 – Jan 2027	Landing page with published indicative prices and the Renewal Radar contract check; 20 office-manager and 10 café-owner interviews; introducer terms from Shire, Novuna and Allica; rental and demo-loan terms from 3 operators or dealers (Logic Vending, Rental+, a rolling-rental operator); written engineer rates from 2 subcontractors (Coffee Lady, a Fracino partner); white-label bean samples	About £500–£1,500 (site, tools, samples, travel)	At least 2 lessors and 1 rolling-rental partner signed; written engineer SLA and rates; at least 30 contract checks completed
1: Launch S1	Feb – Jun 2027	One home region; limited companies only; free two-week trials; one Chamber or BID member offer; one coworking showroom; own-label beans on 30-day terms	About £800–£2,000 (trial consumables, bean minimum, collateral)	At least 10 signed offices; at least 2 fee types paid; SLA met on at least 90% of calls
2: Add S2 and S3; pilot S5	Jul – Dec 2027	Become an IAR of an authorised principal; sign 2–3 roasters; launch the pause-able seasonal plan before the garden-centre season; partner badge for out-of-area independents; three-site amenity pilot (dealership, gym, salon)	Funded from Phase 1 contribution	IAR in place; at least 5 café deals; at least 3 active network partners; pilot sites at 15+ cups a day

PHASE	TIMING	WHAT HAPPENS	EST. CASH OUTLAY (ESTIMATE)	GATE TO PROCEED (SUGGESTED)
3: Gates	2028	S4 earn-out on one small book; S6 Care Club in the home region; refurbished commercial machines (idea 10) once engineer costs are proven	Case by case, earn-out structured	Lessor consent to assignment; retained-customer rate of at least 85% at 6 months
4: Options	2028+	Telemetry uptime tier; public-sector frameworks once references exist; Matchmaker home side option	Case by case	Evidence-led

Indicative unit economics: S1 small office (all estimates)

Assumptions: a 25-person office at about 2 cups per person a day (Rental+), so about 50 drinks a day for 250 days. That suits a Jura-class machine rated "up to 50 cups per day" (Jurang). Ingredient spend scales from Cheshire Vending's £5,600 a year for 150 drinks a day (Cheshire Vending).

LINE (ESTIMATE)	ROUTE A: ROLLING RENTAL VIA PARTNER	ROUTE B: LESSOR-FUNDED, OWN SERVICE AND BEANS
One-off introducer fee from operator	£100–£250 (assumption; unpublished)	n/a
Machine margin as supplier of record on a ~£2,500 package	n/a	£375–£625 (assumed 15–25%; unpublished)
Lessor commission (2–5% of £2,500)	n/a	£50–£125
Ingredients revenue, ~12,500 drinks a year	Only if the partner allows own beans	About £1,870 a year
Ingredient margin at an assumed 25–35%	£0–£650 a year	£470–£650 a year

LINE (ESTIMATE)	ROUTE A: ROLLING RENTAL VIA PARTNER	ROUTE B: LESSOR-FUNDED, OWN SERVICE AND BEANS
Service plan at £35 a month (below Coffee Lady's £399.50 Jura package), less 2 subcontract visits at ~£120–£150	n/a	£0–£180 a year (one reactive £185 callout wipes it out)
Indicative 3-year contribution	**£100–£2,200**	**about £1,800–£3,200**

The lesson: **service protects the relationship, while coffee and the machine deal make the money.** That is why remote triage and a written engineer SLA matter more than a nice-looking price list. At Bark's £7–£40 per lead and an assumed 1-in-5 conversion, acquisition costs about £35–£200 per office, well inside the contribution.

Indicative unit economics: S2 café deal (all estimates)

LINE (ESTIMATE)	BASIS	VALUE
Lessor commission	2–5% of a £10k two-group package	£200–£500 one-off
Machine margin (if supplier of record)	Assumed 10–20%; unpublished	£1,000–£2,000 one-off
Service plan	Charge £45 a month; 2 visits at assumed £150–£200 subcontract	£140–£240 a year
Roaster referral or retainer	Negotiable; unpublished	Assumption: £0–£250 per placed café
Indicative first-year contribution		**about £1,300–£3,000**

07

A B2B launch built on exposing lock-in

The best low-cost buzz for business buyers comes from **publishing what the industry hides and offering proof in the buyer's own building.** The tactics below rely on proven formats: free office trials (Hot Numbers), member-body offers (NI Chamber), showrooms where buyers "try first" (Nu Vending), and instant quote tools (Admiral Vending's AI quote tool) (Hot Numbers; NI Chamber; The London Economic; Vending Times).

STAGE	TACTIC	WHY IT WORKS WITH BUSINESS BUYERS	EST. COST (ESTIMATE)
Pre-launch	**"Lock-In Amnesty" Renewal Radar:** upload a coffee contract and get a plain-English report of the notice date, rollover risk and true cost, plus calendar reminders	Targets the 90-day notice trap; every report is a dated switching lead	Founder time plus £0–£100 a month of tools
Pre-launch	**UK Office Coffee Price Index:** published prices for common machines and a quarterly data story using Caffia's and others' published lease rates	Journalists and FM press like data; it positions the brand as the honest source	£0–£500
Launch	**"Taste-Off in your office":** a free two-week trial with a blind cupping of the current coffee against the business's own coffee on day one	The Hot Numbers trial format plus a moment staff talk about	Beans and courier, £30–£60 per trial
Launch	**Chamber, BID and coworking deals:** an exclusive member price and a showroom machine in a coworking lounge	Borrowed trust and hundreds of SMEs passing the machine daily	£0–£300 a month in coffee
Launch	**Founder LinkedIn series:** "coffee as a return-to-office perk", with occupancy data and a running tally of contracts rescued	Office managers and FM leads live on LinkedIn; costs only time	Time
Sustain	**Public response-time scoreboard** for the business's own service calls	Turns the SLA into proof; no competitor publishes one	Time, and telemetry later
Sustain	**Pause-button launch for seasonal sites**, timed for garden centres in February	Trade-press story with a clear contrast to no-pause free-on-loan terms	Collateral
Sustain	**Partner badge for independents** (S3)	Each partner promotes the standard to its own customers	Badge design

STAGE	TACTIC	WHY IT WORKS WITH BUSINESS BUYERS	EST. COST (ESTIMATE)
Launch	**Local networking circuit** (Business Buzz, Chambers, BNI-style groups), copying Coffee Lady's networking-led growth	Coffee Lady credits networking with building its business	£10–£30 per event
Sustain	**Review engine**: ask every trial and every service visit for a Google review	Coffee Lady's "5.0★ Google-rated" and Office Coffee Company's Trustpilot 5.0 set the bar	Time

Two warnings apply. Incentivised reviews have been explicitly unlawful since 6 April 2025, with CMA fines of up to 10% of turnover (KPMG), so reviews must never be bought. And Grind's £3.8m marketing year shows that buzz without recurring margin burns cash (World Coffee Portal).

08

Risks, compliance and contract checklist

Key risks

RISK	EVIDENCE	MITIGATION
Engineer cost or slow response breaks the promise	£185 PAYG callouts; response time drives choice above 200 drinks a day	Written subcontract SLA and rates before launch; remote triage; one home region first
"No lock-in" is misleading on a finance lease	Leases are fixed 2–5-year terms with break fees	Say "no auto-renewal, published buy-out" for Route B; offer Route A for true flexibility
Partners cut the business out	Operators and independents meet customers directly	VendLocus-style trigger and 12-month non-circumvention
FCA breach with sole traders	Sole traders and partnerships of 2–3 are regulated	Limited companies only until IAR appointment
Free-on-loan partners block own beans	Contracts tie consumables to the operator	Ask at Phase 0; favour rolling-rental partners
Coffee Lady and nationals copy transparency	Caffia already publishes lease prices	Move first on renewal data, partner standard and response scoreboard
Book acquisition destroys value	Unknown multiples; lessor consent needed	Earn-out only; start as a subcontractor
Seasonal pause leaves idle assets	Who funds winter is unsolved	Pause applies to service and beans; lessor terms agreed up front

Compliance and contract checklist

Items marked "verify" come from background knowledge or secondary sources and need checking with a solicitor or the primary regulator.

OBLIGATION	APPLIES WHEN	ACTION
B2B auto-renewal is generally enforceable if properly incorporated (Sprintlaw)	All business contracts	Own contracts: no auto-renewal, or 30-day rolling with reminders; put notice dates on page one
Lease and service are often separate contracts (Barista Life)	Route B and S2	One summary sheet covering both; service cancellable on 30 days' notice
Consumer protections (CRA 2015, DMCC subscription rules) do not protect businesses (notes; verify)	B2B sales	Do not rely on them; the business's own terms are the protection
Unfair Contract Terms Act 1977 reasonableness test on exclusion clauses (verify)	Own B2B terms	Keep liability caps reasonable; have terms reviewed
FCA credit broking: limited companies unregulated; sole traders and partnerships of 2–3 regulated (Novuna)	Any finance introduction	Limited companies only in Phase 1; IAR appointment before S2
Commission disclosure after Johnson v FirstRand (Asset Finance Connect)	Every financed deal	Written disclosure of commission source and amount
FOS may cover micro-enterprises for regulated finance (verify)	IAR phase	Complaints process ready before IAR
Electrical Equipment (Safety) Regulations 2016; UKCA or CE accepted (GOV.UK)	Every machine supplied	Supply only marked, branded machines
WEEE: Valpak DTS (household sales; £112.50 minimum to 31 Dec 2026) (Valpak); non-household take-back rules differ (verify)	Prosumer sales; business machines	Join DTS for S6; agree end-of-life take-back with suppliers
Food-contact materials Reg 1935/2004 (legislation.gov.uk)	Refurbished or pre-owned machines	Replace brew-path seals; documented deep clean
Pressure-vessel examination for espresso boilers, Gas Safe work on LPG van machines, and water-supply fittings rules (verify)	Installation and service	Contractually require subcontractors to hold the relevant competencies and insurance
Fake and incentivised reviews unlawful from 6 April 2025 (Hill Dickinson)	All marketing	No paid reviews; label any incentives
Non-circumvention and fee trigger (VendLocus)	Every introducer and partner deal	Written agreement before the first referral
Contract and lease assignment with lessor consent	S4 acquisitions	Due diligence on every customer contract

OBLIGATION	APPLIES WHEN	ACTION
VAT registration at £90,000 (GOV.UK)	Growth	Register early if most customers are VAT-registered businesses
Public liability, product liability and professional indemnity insurance (not priced)	All phases	Get quotes in Phase 0

09

Who to contact, what to watch, what to validate

Suppliers, partners and competitors

NAME	ROLE	WHY / FIRST QUESTION
Coffee Lady (Aylesbury; Jan Revill, sole trader, FCA FRN 1004670)	Competitor, engineer subcontractor, sole-trader lease referrals before IAR, own-label bean buyer, S3/S4 candidate	Subcontract rates and area; finance partners; interest in referrals and a coffee line; long-term plans
Logic Vending; Coinadrink; Cheshire Vending; Canny Coffee	Independents: partners and competitors	Demo-loan terms; referral appetite; out-of-area gaps
United Vending; Redber; Verde; Rental+	Rolling-rental and service-inclusive partners for Route A	Introducer fee; will they supply own-label beans?
UK Vending Ltd (Kent); Hornblower Businesses	Succession watch; broker	Owner plans; typical deal structures
Shire Leasing; Novuna; Allica; UTB	Lessors	Introducer agreement, commission grid, IAR principal route
Fracino; Coffetek; Jurang (Jura, Franke, Bravilor dealer)	Manufacturers and dealers	Dealer criteria, trade pricing, demo units
Fiamma; Style Café; NMII; The Coffee Lobby	Drop-ship and trade supply	Reseller discount, delivery and install options
Coffee Clinic; Cortile; All Things Coffee; Espresso Care Solutions; The Coffee Guys; Mulmar	Subcontract engineers	Per-visit and callout rates, response SLA, coverage
Bridge; Capital Coffee; Clifton; Dark Woods; Union; Ue Coffee Roasters	Roaster partners for S2	Appetite to outsource equipment and service
Caffè Society; Redber; Extract; Wogan; Hot Numbers	Own-label beans	Per-kg price at 20/50/100 kg; bag setup

NAME	ROLE	WHY / FIRST QUESTION
Catering Units; Really Awesome Coffee; Coffee Latino; The Big Coffee	Van-builder referrers (after IAR)	Referral terms
Vendon; Nayax	Telemetry (Phase 4)	Kit and monthly fees
Bark; Approved Index; Expert Market; coffeebroker.net; Admiral Vending	Lead channels and quote-tool competitors	Coffee-category lead prices
Caffia; Liquidline; Selecta; Lavazza Professional; Nestlé Professional; Matthew Algie; Costa Express	Nationals to watch	Pricing moves, acquisitions, territory partners
Bella Barista; Machina; Espresso Underground; Servicedbyjamie; Barista Boutique	Premium-home benchmarks and service partners for S6	Service capacity; trade-in appetite

Open questions to validate

The decisive unknowns are commercial terms that nobody publishes: **trade margins on bean-to-cup machines, operator introducer fees, lessor commission grids for coffee packages, and subcontract engineer rates and SLAs.** Each recommended idea depends on at least two of them, so Phase 0 exists to get them in writing. Buyer behaviour is the second gap. There is no UK survey of who decides on office coffee, how buyers research it, how often they switch or how many miss their renewal window. The 30 Phase 0 interviews and the contract checks should answer these. Several points need confirming: whether rolling-rental partners will accept the business's own beans, sector volumes for dealerships, gyms and salons, seasonal café economics, and willingness to pay for prosumer care plans. For acquisitions, valuation multiples, owner-age profiles and lessor assignment rules are all unknown. On the legal side, have a solicitor confirm the UCTA, FOS micro-enterprise, pressure-system, Gas Safe, water-fittings and non-household WEEE points marked "verify". Some sources are also weaker than they look. Several independents' prices come from search snippets, Capital Coffee's and Verde's pages show conflicting minimums, and Cheshire Vending's lease-cost example contradicts its own percentage claim.

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Conclusion

The B2B pivot turns the user's constraint into an advantage. In the home market, a newcomer without capital has to compete on price. In workplace and hospitality coffee, the people who hold capital (lessors, rolling-rental operators and roasters) want someone to find and keep customers, and the customers resent the way existing capital-holders lock them in. The business

owns no machines. What it owns is the contract design, published prices, response-time data and the renewal calendar. Coffee Lady shows that a founder-led independent can serve 500 businesses on service and expertise. It also shows that the same model, without coffee supply, trials, rolling terms or consistent published prices, still leaves the most valuable recurring relationship unclaimed. That relationship is the opportunity.

The panel's results also show what does not work. Every idea that needed the business's own stock or cash (refurbishment, self-serve fleets, a cash book purchase, pre-owned prosumer machines) failed on Procurement, and every idea that hid the business behind someone else's brand failed on Marketing and Design. The recommended ideas pass because they keep the brand at the front while partners carry the equipment and credit behind it. The near misses point to the most likely later step. Once the partner network has built trust, retiring independents' customer books can be bought on earn-out without upfront capital. The partner network is therefore both a revenue source and the way into acquisitions.

The seven reviewers are simulated expert personas scoring against the cited evidence, not real people. Figures marked "estimate" are illustrative arithmetic, not supplier quotes. Validate trade terms directly before committing.